

1 — How It Should Look and Feel

(Plain-English version of [docs/09-design-principles.md](#). If you want the full technical detail, read that file.)

This is the most important guide. It describes the feeling every screen must have.

The feeling in three words

Warm. Calm. Alive.

- **Warm** — rounded shapes, soft warm colours, friendly words, and drawings of real people.
- **Calm** — lots of space, one main thing per screen, quiet colours. No badges or dots fighting for attention.
- **Alive** — gentle movement and small happy moments. Think of a leaf slowly growing, not confetti popping.

Picture a bright, welcoming church youth hall on a Sunday morning: full of life, but calm when it is time to read. That is the feeling. It should be the **opposite** of a noisy social feed.

The Bible reader is the calmest screen of all. When a teen is reading, the design should almost disappear.

One main idea per screen. The Today screen shows one thing: today's reading and its verse. Not a busy dashboard.

Words / fonts

- One clear, friendly font for the app. It must be very easy to read.
- The Bible reader can offer a second, softer "book" font as an option.
- Body text is never smaller than 16px. In the Bible it starts at 18px, and the reader can make it bigger or smaller (from 14px up to 28px).
- Keep lines of text a comfortable width — not too wide.

Space

- Give things room to breathe. Cramped screens feel stressful.

- Everything lines up to a small 4px grid. On phones: about 24px between cards, and at least 16px of padding inside them.
- Empty space is a good thing, not wasted space.

Colours

- Backgrounds are a soft off-white — never pure white (easier on the eyes and on phone batteries).
- Text is a soft dark colour — never pure black.
- **Green** is the main colour (the “growing” 🌱 colour). Use it only for the important things: main buttons, the active tab, streak moments. If everything is green, nothing stands out.
- **Amber** (warm yellow) is only for celebration moments.
- Red is only for real errors. Never use red on streaks or games.
- Every colour pairing must be easy to read (pass contrast checks).

Must-haves for everyone (accessibility)

This is a rule for launch, not a nice extra:

- Taps must be at least 44 × 44px (fingers on cheap phones are not precise).
- Everything still works if the user makes text twice as big.
- Never use colour alone to mean something — always add an icon or a label.
- Screen readers must be able to read everything out.
- Respect “reduce motion” settings — turn animations off for people who ask.

Movement

Movement has only three jobs: help people know where things came from, show that something worked, and (rarely) celebrate.

- Keep it quick: most movements 150–250ms; celebrations a little longer.
- Celebrations are gentle and happen at most once per session. A leaf unfurling, not a confetti cannon.
- No blinking, no looping, no shaking, no pulsing dots.

Pictures and drawings

- Use warm, friendly **drawings** that show **Nigerian teens** — real skin tones, hair, school and church life. Not stock Western youth-group photos.
- Use drawings for welcome screens, empty screens, and milestone moments. Never as random filler.
- Real **photos** appear only in the Tribe section (events). Never on the daily Bible or Today screens — those stay calm and drawn/typographic.

Dark mode

- Every screen needs a dark version from day one (teens read at night).
- Dark backgrounds are a soft dark colour, not pure black.
- The Bible reader also gets a third “sepia” mode — a warm, paper-like colour for comfortable reading.
- Follow the phone’s setting by default, but let the user choose.

Loading and waiting

- Show a soft grey placeholder shape (a “skeleton”), not a spinning wheel.
- Show yesterday’s saved content instantly, then quietly refresh.
- For long things (payment, upload) show progress and a calm, reassuring message.

The 7 things to NEVER do

1. No endless scrolling in the teen app.
2. No videos that auto-play.
3. No scary “your streak is about to die!” messages. Reminders are always warm and kind.
4. No sneaky tricks (guilt messages, hidden ads, forced sharing).
5. No busy admin-style clutter in the teen screens.
6. No trendy redesigns that break the calm feeling.
7. No like counts, follower counts, or popularity numbers on friends or profiles. *(The one exception: community notes will have public likes and reposts — but that is a later version.)*